

Tactical genius

When the Civil War broke out, the tough 40-year-old Memphis slave-trader and planter had no military experience. Of all the war's famous generals, he was the only one who was neither a professional soldier nor a graduate of West Point. Yet his tactical victories, especially at Brice's Crossroads in June 1864, were so brilliantly executed that they are still studied. His cavalry fought as mounted infantry, the horses being used for speed of movement. When battle loomed, his men tethered their horses, then advanced in loose formation as infantry skirmishers. Never having read an artillery manual, Forrest ran his guns up to the very front of his line, often with devastating effect.

Even military superiors quailed before his hair-trigger temper. "If you ever again try to interfere with me," he threatened General Braxton Bragg, "or cross my path it will be at the peril of your life." In battle such fury might be targeted at the enemy. However, his temper does not seem to have been the issue when his forces attacked the Union position at Fort Pillow, Tennessee, in April 1864. An indiscriminate butchery that began in the furor of combat ultimately took the lives of nearly two-thirds of the Union garrison, including nearly 200 Black troops, many slain while surrendering. The question remains open whether Forrest did or did not order, or condone, a deliberate massacre. At the very least, he bears the responsibility for his men's actions.

At the war's end, Lieutenant General Forrest surrendered his command and urged his men to become good citizens. In 1866, however, ex-Confederate veterans, who feared that Radical Reconstruction would eradicate cherished Southern traditions, founded a secret paramilitary organization, the Ku Klux Klan. They recruited Forrest, who is thought to have become the organization's first grand wizard. The Klan was intent on defending a way of life whose bedrock had been enslavement and white supremacy. Its vigilante bands began terrorizing freedmen across the South, and this brought a crackdown by the Federal government. In 1869,